

Phase 3: Triggers & Projections – The Mirror

“Everything that irritates us about others can lead us to an understanding of ourselves.”

— C.G. Jung

You may notice a flash of heat rising in your chest as you bring to mind someone who truly bothers you. Perhaps your jaw tightens, or your hands clench involuntarily. This visceral reaction—this **trigger**—is your body’s urgent signal that something unintegrated is asking to be seen. **The mirror is offering its reflection.**

Projection is one of Jung's most revolutionary discoveries. It describes an unconscious defense mechanism where we **externalize** our own unacceptable qualities, disowning them in ourselves and perceiving them intensely in others. The arrogance that enrages you in your colleague may be your own unacknowledged ambition. The neediness that repels you in a friend may be your own disowned longing for connection.

This is not to say that others are never genuinely harmful or problematic. But when the emotional charge is **disproportionate**—when you find yourself obsessing, seething, or irrationally disturbed—the shadow is speaking. The nervous system responds to projections as if to an external threat, triggering the sympathetic fight-or-flight response. Your heart races, your breath shallows, your prefrontal cortex goes offline.

The 3-2-1 process, developed by Ken Wilber, offers a pathway back: you move from **facing** the trigger (it/them), to **talking** to it (you), to **becoming** it (I). In doing so, you reclaim the exiled energy you have unconsciously projected onto the world—and that energy returns as power, creativity, and wholeness. The trigger becomes the teacher.

In this phase, you will:

- Identify your biggest triggers and decode what they reveal about your shadow
- Map where triggers activate in your body through somatic tracking
- Use the 3-2-1 process to integrate projections

- Reclaim the lost energy you have outsourced to external blame